

A scramble to make progress in trade talks

As negotiations begin, one Trump official vows results within weeks

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM, NATALIE ALLISON AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

President Donald Trump and his top trade advisers on Thursday opened up the White House to trade negotiations with more than a dozen countries that one official vowed would bear results within weeks even as an escalating trade war with China showed no signs of abating.

As countries scrambled to avoid the full blast of the heavy tariffs that Trump paused Wednesday, senior White House officials said they were satisfied with the first meetings they were taking, with countries offering to pull down trade barriers and make U.S. investments as they tried to understand what might save their businesses from the tax wallop. Several White House officials quoted in this article spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive internal considerations.

Still, markets swooned, with the S&P 500 on Thursday shedding a third of its jump the previous day — the biggest since 2008 — as investors realized that the president is not backing away from a confrontation with Beijing.

That fight escalated shortly after 11 a.m., when the White House said the tariffs on China now stand at 145 percent, not 125 percent as Trump had previously said. White House officials declined to detail a pathway out of the confrontation, with one senior official acknowledging that it

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Europe: Relief and bewilderment after abrupt reversal of levies. **A9**

Vietnam vulnerable: Trump's tariffs put the country in a bind. **A10**

Stock market: Escalating trade war with China sparks sell-off. **A11**



KEVIN FRAYER/GETTY IMAGES

A vendor and customer at a Beijing wholesaler Thursday. China and the United States form more than 40 percent of the world economy.

Protracted trade war looms as U.S., China lock horns

BY JEFF STEIN

The United States and China have sharply raised tariffs on each other's imports over the last week, raising the prospect of a long and painful trade war between the world's two largest economies.

Even as investors rallied to his decision to pause "reciprocal" tariffs on imports from dozens of countries Wednesday, President Donald Trump raised tariffs on Chinese goods to 145 percent — an increase of nearly 50 percent in a day, and his fourth tariff action against Beijing since January. President Xi Jinping has not backed down, either, retaliating by raising China's tariffs on U.S.-made goods to 84 percent

and imposing new curbs on critical resources. (Trump on Wednesday said the tariff rate on China would be 125 percent, but a White House official, speaking on the condition of anonymity to explain government policy, said Thursday the actual rate would be 145 percent.)

U.S. stock markets slid again Thursday as Washington and Beijing showed no sign of an immediate rapprochement. The S&P 500 index, which had posted its biggest one-day leap since 2008 on Wednesday, gave back about a third of those gains. But Trump told reporters he was "very, very happy with the way the country is running."

The intensifying financial hos-

SEE TARIFFS ON A13

Small businesses struggle to keep up with costly chaos

BY CAROLINE O'DONOVAN

Last week, Gina Castagnozzi signed off on a contract to ship thousands of compostable dog waste bags from China to Los Angeles for her pet supply business, Giving Paws. The next day, President Donald Trump raised tariffs on imports from China to 54 percent.

On Tuesday, when her goods had been at sea for days, Trump said his China tariffs would rise to 104 percent. On Wednesday, he raised them again to 125 percent.

"I can't believe he did that," said Castagnozzi, who worries she won't have the cash to pay the bill when her bags arrive in about two weeks. "You have to give people enough warning to strate-

gically plan for this." A White House official said on Thursday that the actual rate on Chinese imports would be 145 percent.

Castagnozzi is one of the many American small-business owners who source goods from overseas — especially from suppliers and factories in China — and sell them online and via e-commerce platforms like Amazon. As Trump's mercurial trade policy sent stock markets plunging this week, those independent retailers faced acute uncertainty about how the tariffs would affect their businesses and livelihoods.

Even those who welcomed Trump's response to what they describe as unfair competition from China are starting to feel

SEE SELLERS ON A13

Living migrants classified as dead

ADDED TO DATABASE BY SOCIAL SECURITY

Administration pressures the 6,000 to 'self report'

BY LISA REIN, HANNAH NATANSON AND MARIA SACCHETTI

The Social Security Administration this week entered the names and Social Security numbers of more than 6,000 mostly Latino immigrants into a database it uses to track dead people, effectively erasing their ability to receive benefits or work legally in the United States, according to four people familiar with the situation and records obtained by The Washington Post.

The move, requested by Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem, is aimed at putting pressure on the undocumented immigrants to leave the country, according to a White House official.

Among the people being targeted are immigrants who have bona fide Social Security numbers but have lost their legal status in the U.S., such as those who entered under one of the Biden administration's temporary work programs that have since ended.

The White House official — who spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the sensitivity of the new program — said those who were moved into the Social Security database this week all have ties to terrorist activity or criminal records. The official did not provide evidence of the alleged crimes or terrorist ties but said some are included on the FBI's terror watch list.

"President Trump promised mass deportations and by removing the monetary incentive for illegal aliens to come and stay, we

SEE SOCIAL SECURITY ON A12

Outcry in N.Y.: Border czar's town wins release of three students. **A6**

On a chilly Colo. plain, a cold case of missing cows

The disappearance of 187 head of cattle from a family ranch prompts an extensive state investigation

BY KARIN BRULLIARD

OLATHE, COLORADO — The first report was filed just before Thanksgiving. Twenty-nine cows and calves, a rancher told a state agriculture official, hadn't come home.

One week later, three more reports from three other owners: 46, 38 and 31 head of cattle, all gone. Three days after that, rancher Kelly Burch also alerted authorities. She had counted her herd and come up 43 animals short.

"I have this cow, but not this calf. Or I have this calf, but not this cow," said Burch, whose family has run cattle on the same swath of public land for 106 years. "Something's not adding up here."

All 187 missing bovines had spent the warmer months grazing thousands of acres on the high Uncompahgre Plateau, rugged country where some animals always fall victim to predators, illness or weather. But never this many and not without leaving lots of carcasses behind. Also unusual: The vast majority were calves.

Ranchers and local authorities suspected they might have a modern-day case of cattle rustling on

SEE COWS ON A14



JACOB SPETZLER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Cows stand in freezing rain on a hill on Kelly Burch's ranch in Olathe, Colorado. More than 100 of her cattle have gone missing since November, prompting an investigation, a reward and more.

Justices back order for return of Md. deportee

Trump must 'facilitate' release after error sent man to Salvadoran prison

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL AND ANN E. MARIMOW

The Supreme Court on Thursday backed a lower-court order requiring the Trump administration to "facilitate" the release from custody of a Maryland man who was mistakenly deported to a mega-prison in El Salvador last month.

A district court judge had ordered Kilmar Abrego García to be brought back to the United States by Monday night, but Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. issued a brief pause hours before the deadline, allowing the justices time to weigh a government motion to block the order.

In its brief order Thursday evening, the high court said the judge "properly requires the Government to 'facilitate' Abrego García's release from custody in El Salvador and to ensure that his case is handled as it would have

been had he not been improperly sent to El Salvador."

The Supreme Court's unsigned order does not mean Abrego García will be returned immediately. The justices sent the case back to the lower-court judge to clarify aspects of her initial order and said the Trump administration should be prepared to "share what it can concerning the steps it has taken and the prospect of further steps."

There were no noted dissents. The case has become a major flash point over President Donald Trump's mass-deportation campaign. Abrego García's attorneys have said their client is the victim of a "Kafkaesque mistake," and critics say the government's contention that a judge has no power to order his return raises the possibility that other noncitizens could be whisked to a foreign country with little recourse.

In a separate immigration-related ruling on Monday, the Supreme Court lifted a block on the administration's use of the Alien Enemies Act to try to deport alleged Venezuelan gang members but said the government must give potential deportees no-

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IN THE NEWS

Trump proposals advance The GOP-led House approved an agreement to begin implementing the president's agenda on taxes, energy and immigration. **A4**

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Some D.C. residents and lawyers fear the interim U.S. attorney's gun crackdown marks a return to racially targeted enforcement. **B1**

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WEEKEND
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The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54183

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